

GOALS AND HEIRS

The FIFA World Cup has historically set the stage for some legendary eras. From Pelé and Diego Maradona, to Zinedine Zidane and Ronaldo Nazário – one showstopper almost always marked the quadrennial showpiece.

The 21st century has had two such stars:

Lionel Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo. The duo, in the twilight of their careers, are heading into their sixth and potentially last World Cup. However, the 2026 edition also sees a new duopoly on the horizon, between France and Real Madrid star Kylian Mbappe and Manchester City and Norway icon Erling Haaland.

And, the FIFA World Cup 2026 will be the first and only edition of the tournament to witness the change of hands between the old and new stars of modern football.

Sportstar looks at what these players bring to the grandest show on earth, in the biggest edition of the tournament so far.

3 NATIONS
U.S.A. 
CANADA 
MEXICO 

11 JUNE - 19 JULY
2026 

HOST CITIES
16 

LIONEL MESSI AND CRISTIANO RONALDO SEEK ONE FINAL FLOURISH AS KYLIAN MBAPPE AND ERLING HAALAND PREPARE TO INHERIT FOOTBALL'S GRANDEST STAGE, THE FIFA WORLD CUP



FIFA

